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Response to Robinson's "What Kind of Country Do We Want?"

"What Kind of Country Do We Want" by Marilynne Robinson explores several of the most pertinent questions facing the United States, and by proxy, the rest of the world in the modern age. It appears that her primary purpose is to explore how the United States got into the position it finds itself in today, and what should be done about it. One of the main ideas in her essay is that of American unhappiness, which Robinson contextualizes with respect to the many problems in the country. This essay will seek to further expand upon the ideas established in Robinson's work.

Early in her essay, Robinson calls into question the validity and the effectiveness of the American "system", which she ponders can even be called a system to begin with. The author writes "the system itself is now revealed as a tenuous set of arrangements that have been highly profitable for some people but gravely damaging to the world." (Robinson paragraph 2). In this way she establishes the inequality that pervades the entirety of the system, citing this as the primary cause of American unhappiness while also questioning whether the system should even qualify as such. The word system implies a set of concrete rules and regulations, it is robust and meant to be the foundation for something larger. It is meant to serve the people for which it was designed, ideally everyone who is involved. System is defined by Merriam-Webster as "a regularly interacting or interdependent group of items forming a unified whole", and "a group of devices or artificial objects or an organization forming a network especially for distributing something or serving a common purpose". These things are frequently seen to be untrue in the modern American system where millions of people, namely those of lower socioeconomic stature, are treated unfairly and unequally by the system whose walls have been cracking at the seams. The leading example of this would be the systemic racism which has pervaded the American economic and organizational structure for hundreds of years. There remains to be ongoing brutality against African Americans by police officers across the country, in addition to several archaic and racist practices and doctrines which block or even prevent minorities from voting, finding employment, receiving an education, and many other ideals that many seem to take for granted.

Robinson begins to analyze potential reasons for the flawed system in paragraph 5, citing the "profit motive" which has been ingrained in people's minds for thousands of years, "in our very DNA". It is this idea that people are predominantly concerned about whatever will put them ahead of others, or whatever will help them the most while often disregarding the questions of morality and ethics. The author expands upon this idea, "Much American unhappiness has arisen from the cordoning-off of low-income workers from the reasonable hope that they and their children will be fairly compensated for their work". In the modern age, fewer and fewer people

maintain hope that things will improve, and such pessimism is what leads to a ubiquitous feeling of unhappiness. It is certainly true that thousands of people encounter difficulties and blockages when it comes to advancing their career, and it is the sad reality that financial security has a very strong correlation with happiness. Robinson also recalls the aforementioned “system”, stating “The global economic order has meant that the poor will remain poor”, meaning that happiness is only truly in the cards for those who are higher in the economic hierarchy. From this argument, one may ask the titular question of “what country do we want?”, and thus question how the hypothetical country may be attained. The latter is one of the most complex, difficult, but important questions facing the world today, whose answer will likely be obscured for an untold number of years.

The next idea Robinson explores is the irony of the United States possessing an extremely powerful economy, and still being in a threatened and weak position. She writes, “America is the most powerful economy in history and at the same time so threatened by global competition...national parks are increasingly abandoned to neglect in service to fiscal restraint. We cannot maintain our infrastructure. And, of course, we cannot raise the minimum wage.” The United States spends far more money than it earns, which is why the national debt rises virtually every year, which in turn has a trickle down effect on every person in the country (not to mention the rest of the world as a result). Robinson cites the disregard of national parks to show how the country has found itself in such a difficult position that it cannot even sustain things as important as its parks, let alone its own people and values. The source of this position is the idea of scarcity, where people believe that resources are limited and they must work more rigorously (still without wages necessary to lead a sustainable life or pursue one’s own interests) just to get by. This also leads to the undermining of others in order to get ahead, recalling the argument that the pervasive profit motive turns people against each other through a lack of ethical consideration. The author even argues that those in positions of wealth are subject to unhappiness as well, as their wealth, though private, is diminished by the claims of community. These concepts come together to suggest that virtually every American has reason to be unhappy - one might cite the idea that “the grass is always greener on the other side.” This unhappiness stems from the inability of the United States economy to sustain and improve upon itself, despite its considerable power and influence.

It can also be argued that much of the unhappiness among Americans originates from the educational system. Robinson describes higher education as “financially ruinous” because of its ever-increasing sky-high prices. If someone decides to enroll for higher education, they are making a choice which will have considerable financial impacts, impacts which are almost always negative. Students taking out loans are certainly more likely to experience a significant amount of stress, as they are in effect setting themselves back thousands of dollars with only the hope that they will be in a better position once they complete school and enter the workforce. This hope can be extremely fragile, though, since millions of students struggle with self-confidence and begin to doubt themselves, which can unfortunately decrease the likelihood of success. Robinson also argues that deciding on a college and on a major is essentially a guess,

as there is no way of knowing what will be most beneficial until afterward. Making a poor guess would be very costly, and set people back even further. The author continues, "Those who fail to make the cut will be left with the pleasures of a technical education that is always less useful to them, skills that will be subject to obsolescence as industries change". This suggests that even if a student successfully makes it through the higher education system, and enjoys what they have learned, their skills may be useless as changes in their industries are almost constant and often unpredictable. Such obsolescence can lead to feelings of uselessness, which further diminishes the happiness of millions of Americans as they lose their jobs to cheaper and more efficient alternatives. There would undoubtedly be a great deal of regret as well, since people would probably believe that they had wasted their time and their money on something which is now useless to them. Though trivial as it relates to time, both of these factors are essentially impossible to get back due to the weakness of the American system.

Despite a plethora of issues whose solutions are for the moment mostly unknown, there is reason to believe that the United States will continue to survive. As Robinson writes, "to the degree that democratic habits persist, the country will get by". The author also proposes that potential solutions may be to abandon the concept of competition. She argues that it creates unnecessarily tenuous relationships between large entities as well as small, and that it has been revealed through recent history that our own worst enemies are ourselves as a result of the flawed economic system which favors certain people over others. Robinson also hopes that the country will "get beyond the habit of thinking in terms of scarcity.", which would alleviate the intense "profit motive" causing conflict between many of the country's people.

Combining all of the information and arguments, it can be said that the number one solution to the problems facing the United States and the rest of the world is to increase the rigor of self-examinations. It is undeniably crucial that people, and countries as a whole, are honest with themselves in their retrospection, as failure to be so only perpetuates and exacerbates the aforementioned problems, making them exponentially more difficult to solve. That said, the essay inspires a level of hope in that it reminds the reader that human nature proves that giving up is not an option. The people of the United States have been through considerable plight, but continue to push forward with the hope of creating a better country. A country that helps each and every individual equally, a country which kindles happiness instead of extinguishing it, and a country whose people can be truly proud to be a part of.

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https://www.nybooks.com/articles/2020/06/11/what-kind-of-country-do-we-want/?lp_txn_id=1279728

Other Sources:

<https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/system>